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Belshazzar

The last ruler of Babylon, who feasted while his kingdom fell and was "weighed in the balances, and ... found wanting."

Belshazzar ruled Babylon in its final years. On the night the city fell, he threw a great feast for a thousand of his lords. With the wine flowing, he sent for the gold and silver cups that Nebuchadnezzar had taken from the temple in Jerusalem, and his guests drank from them while praising their idols. Suddenly the fingers of a man's hand appeared and wrote on the palace wall. None of his wise men could read it. The aged Daniel was brought in. He reminded the king how God had humbled Nebuchadnezzar and told him that God had now weighed him and found him wanting. That same night Belshazzar was killed, and Babylon passed to the Medes and Persians. His story is a sober warning about pride that will not learn.

At a glance

Name	Babylonian <i>Bel-shar-usur</i> , usually explained as "Bel, protect the king"
Family	Nebuchadnezzar his "father" (Daniel 5:2); records say son of Nabonidus
Position	Ruled for his father; could offer only "third ruler" (Daniel 5:7)
When	Ruled from c. 553 BC (uncertain); died 539 BC
Key people	Daniel; "the queen"; Darius the Mede
Main passages	Daniel 5; 7:1; 8:1
New Testament	Not named

"TEKEL; Thou art weighed in the balances, and art found wanting."

Daniel 5:27, KJV

The life of Belshazzar

Dates are approximate (BC). Scripture dates two of Daniel's visions by Belshazzar's reign. The start of that reign is uncertain but is usually placed c. 553 BC.

c. 553 BC 1st year	● A vision in his reign In the first year of Belshazzar, Daniel dreams of four beasts from the sea and of one like the Son of man who receives an everlasting kingdom. Daniel writes the dream down. <i>Daniel 7:1-14</i>
c. 551 BC 3rd year	● Another vision In his third year, Daniel sees a ram and a goat, a vision of kingdoms to come. The ram's two horns are later explained as "the kings of Media and Persia." <i>Daniel 8:1-4, 20</i>
c. 539 BC The last night	● The feast Belshazzar gives a feast for a thousand lords. He orders the temple vessels brought, and his court drinks from them while praising gods of gold, silver, bronze, iron, wood and stone. <i>Daniel 5:1-4</i>
The same night	● The writing on the wall Fingers of a man's hand appear and write on the plaster near the lampstand. The king turns pale and his knees knock. His wise men cannot read it, and the queen reminds him of Daniel. <i>Daniel 5:5-16</i>
The same night	● Weighed and found wanting Daniel refuses the king's gifts and reads the message: MENE, MENE, TEKEL, UPHARSIN. Belshazzar keeps his word and honours Daniel, but that same night he is killed. Darius the Mede takes the kingdom. <i>Daniel 5:17-31</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Who was "Darius the Median" (Daniel 5:31)? He has not yet been found in records outside the Bible. Some identify him with Cyrus himself, some with Cyrus's governor Gubaru, and some with a Median king. Others think the book uses a different tradition. The text simply says he took the kingdom at about sixty-two.

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- 1 **Threw a great feast.** He feasted with a thousand lords on the very night his kingdom would fall. *Daniel 5:1*
 - 2 **Mocked the God of Israel.** He drank from the holy vessels taken from Jerusalem and praised idols. *Daniel 5:2-4*
 - 3 **Saw the hand.** When the fingers wrote on the wall, he was terrified: "the joints of his loins were loosed, and his knees smote one against another." *Daniel 5:5-6*
 - 4 **Offered rich rewards.** He promised scarlet robes, a gold chain and third place in the kingdom to anyone who could read the writing. *Daniel 5:7, 16*
 - 5 **Ignored the lesson he knew.** Daniel told him, "thou his son, O Belshazzar, hast not humbled thine heart, though thou knewest all this." *Daniel 5:18-23*
 - 6 **Honoured Daniel.** Even after hearing his doom, he kept his word and clothed Daniel in scarlet. *Daniel 5:29*
 - 7 **Died that night.** "In that night was Belshazzar the king of the Chaldeans slain." *Daniel 5:30*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Belshazzar.

Old Testament

Daniel 5:1–31	This is the main account of his feast and death.
Daniel 7:1; 8:1	Two of Daniel's visions are dated by his reign.
Daniel 4:28–37	This is the humbling of Nebuchadnezzar that Belshazzar knew about and ignored.
Isaiah 21:5, 9	and Jeremiah 51:39, 57 . These prophecies of Babylon's fall mention feasting and drunken princes. Many readers see them fulfilled on Belshazzar's last night.
Echoes	"Pride goeth before destruction, and an haughty spirit before a fall" (Proverbs 16:18).

New Testament

Echoes	The rich fool plans to "eat, drink, and be merry," but God says, "this night thy soul shall be required of thee" (Luke 12:19–20). "God is not mocked" (Galatians 6:7). "Babylon is fallen, is fallen" (Revelation 14:8).
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For discussion

- Observe:* What did Belshazzar do with the vessels from God's temple, and what did his guests praise (Daniel 5:2–4)?
- Understand:* Daniel says Belshazzar "knewest all this." Why is knowing the truth and ignoring it so serious?
- Apply:* What lesson from someone else's life, or from your own past, do you need to take seriously now?
- Apply:* Belshazzar treated holy things as party cups. What is something God has given you that you want to treat with more respect this week?